A Midsummer Night's Dream: Characters

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

Download PDF

Written by: Nadia Ambreen
Reviewed by: Kate Lee
Updated on 15 October 2024

Characters

Understanding that characters are often used symbolically to express ideas is critical to reading a Shakespearean play. William Shakespeare often used characters to represent or reflect ideas that were prevalent in Elizabethan society. Therefore, it is useful not only to learn about each character individually but also to consider them in comparison to other characters in the play.

When thinking about characters, try to consider the wide range of strategies used by Shakespeare to create and develop characters within A Midsummer Night's Dream. These include:

- How characters are established
- How characters are presented:
  - Physical appearance or suggestions about this
  - Their actions and motives
  - What they say and think
  - How they interact with others
  - What others say and think about them
- How far the characters conform to or subvert stereotypes
- Their relationships to other characters

Below you will find character profiles of:

Main characters

- Hermia
- Lysander
- Helena
- Demetrius
- Puck

Other characters

- Theseus
- Oberon
- Titania
- Bottom

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

Shakespeare has deliberately created characters to perform certain dramatic functions within the play.

For example, try and think about why Shakespeare has chosen to present Bottom in the way that he does. Why was his head transformed into a donkey's head? What characteristics does he have that Shakespeare is perhaps mocking? Try and explore reasons as to why Shakespeare has chosen to do this and what it might suggest about the character.

Hermia

- Hermia is a young woman from Athens
- She is the daughter of a **nobleman** named Egeus
- Hermia is in love with Lysander and refuses to marry her father's choice, Demetrius
- She is old friends with Helena:
  - She confides in Helena when she and Lysander decide to **elope**
- She is **defiant** and rebellious:
  - She resists her father's wishes for her to marry Demetrius because she does not love him
- From the beginning of the play, the audience sees Hermia's strong will and independence as she is determined to marry Lysander, despite the consequences:
  - She agrees to run away with Lysander to be with him
  - She openly speaks up in front of the Duke, declaring her love for Lysander
  - She threatens Helena and accuses her of stealing him
- She is self-conscious about her short height and displays some vulnerability when Lysander rejects her for Helena
- Hermia's **resilience** is evident as she faces various challenges including the effects of magical spells and related misunderstandings:
  - Throughout all of this, her determination to be with Lysander persists, showing her unwavering love and commitment
- She is a symbol of romantic rebellion, challenging social expectations and authority in the play

Help me understand

Lysander

- Lysander is one of the four central romantic characters in the play:
  - He is in love with Hermia and plays a key role in the romantic conflict involving Hermia, Helena and Demetrius
- Lysander goes against the wishes of Hermia's father, Egeus, by pursuing a relationship with her when her father wants her to marry Demetrius

using his speeches to win Hermia's affection:
    - He represents the **chivalric**, heroic **suitor** whose intentions are honourable and motivated by true love

- Like other characters in the play, Lysander falls victim to Oberon and Puck's magical interference:
    - He is accidentally enchanted and made to fall in love with Helena

- By the end of the play, the magical effects are reversed and Lysander is once again in love with Hermia

Lysander's **persistence** in pursuing Hermia against objections and barriers symbolises the theme of enduring love in the play

Helena

- Helena, another of the four Athenian lovers, is a friend of Hermia's and is in love with Demetrius:
    - It is implied that Helena and Demetrius were once involved but Demetrius abandoned Helena in favour of Hermia

- Demetrius does not return her love and this becomes the focus of Helena's story as she attempts to win his love
- Helena is characterised by a deep sense of **insecurity** and low self-esteem:
    - She believes herself to be unattractive and struggles with feelings of **inadequacy**, especially in comparison to Hermia

- Despite Demetrius's rejection, Helena remains persistent in her pursuit of him:
    - She follows him into the woods, even when it is clear that he does not love her

- Helen is willing to sacrifice her dignity and pride to win Demetrius's love:
    - She betrays her friend, Hermia, by revealing their plan to elope in the hope that Demetrius will be grateful and return her love

- Helena is also a victim of Oberon and Puck's magical interference, which leads her to believe that Hermia, Lysander and Demetrius are mocking her:
    - This adds a layer of sympathy to her character

- By the end of the play, Demetrius returns Helena's love and she achieves a resolution

Demetrius

- Demetrius, a youthful suitor from Athens, seeks the hand of Hermia, with the support of her father, Egeus:
    - However, Hermia is not in love with him

- He is shown to be **fickle** as he was previously linked romantically with Helena before he agreed to marry

love but driven by the laws of the land
- Demetrius rejects Helena, who is deeply in love with him:
  - Despite her persistence in pursuing him, he remains uninterested and is often cruel towards her
- Demetrius also becomes a victim of magical manipulation by Oberon and Puck:
  - Oberon orders Puck to use a love potion, causing him to fall in love with Helena
- Demetrius, under the spell, becomes a symbol of the irrational and unpredictable nature of love in the play
- When Demetrius falls in love with Helena, she does not believe him, which adds to the comedy
- By the end of the play, Demetrius and Helena become a couple

Puck

- Puck, also known as Robin Goodfellow, is a mischievous and playful fairy who serves Oberon, the fairy king:
  - His **antics** contribute to the comedic and magical elements of the play
- He carries out Oberon's commands, including the application of the love potion to various characters:
  - His actions serve as a catalyst for the romantic chaos that ensues in the forest
- Puck uses magic to manipulate the romantic relationships of the mortal characters, leading to humorous misunderstandings:
  - He mistakenly uses the love potion on Lysander rather than Demetrius, which results in confusion and chaos in the forest
- His actions and mistakes drive the plot forward, creating the tangled web of love and confusion that defines the play:
  - He deliberately turns Bottom's head into the head of a donkey
  - He accidentally applies the love potion on the wrong man initially
- Puck's magical spirit and mischievous nature contribute to the enchanted atmosphere of the play:
  - He is fun-loving but also capable of being cruel, which is evident when he transforms Bottom's head
- At the end of the play, Puck expresses remorse for his mistakes

Other characters

Theseus

- He initially **upholds** Egeus's right to choose a husband for Hermia
- He is engaged to Hippolyta and plans to marry her in four days
- He is present at the start and at the end of the play:
  - He has no involvement in anything that happens in the forest

- While he initially supports Egeus's demands for Hermia to marry Demetrius, he later shows compassion and allows the lovers according to their own choices:
  - Theseus demonstrates wisdom and reason in his decisions

Oberon

- Oberon is the king of the fairies
- He is the mastermind behind the magical interventions that create chaos and confusion among the mortal characters in the play:
  - He uses Puck to apply a love potion on Demetrius and also Titania

- His relationship with Titania, the Queen of the fairies, is marked by conflict and jealousy over the possession of a young boy:
  - This conflict begins the chaos and confusion in the rest of the play

- Oberon plays a role in resolving conflict by ensuring that the lovers end up with their desired partners

Titania

- Titania is Queen of the Fairies
- She argues with Oberon, the King of the Fairies, over the possession of a young boy, which leads to tension and discord in the fairy world
- Titania displays a protective and **maternal** side in her concern for the wellbeing of the young boy and her interactions with her attendants
- She falls victim to Oberon's magic when he uses a love potion that makes her fall in love with Bottom
- Titania's **reconciliation** with Oberon and the resolution of their conflict contributes to the overall harmony at the end of the play
- She represents feminine power and strength, challenging traditional gender roles and emphasising the importance of balance between male and female characters

Bottom

- Bottom is introduced as a weaver and a member of an **amateur** acting group who are preparing to perform a play at the Duke's wedding
- He is overconfident and **boastful** about his acting abilities, considering himself capable of performing every role; he provides comic relief in the play
- Bottom is the victim of Puck's mischief, resulting in his head being transformed into a donkey's:
  - His transformation symbolises his absurdity and comic foolishness

Teacher only

Test your students on this in just a few clicks

- Create exam-aligned tests
- Tailor format & difficulty
- Quizzes or homework in minutes

Try Test Builder

Test yourself

Was this revision note helpful? Yes No

Previous Next

Course Study tools All topics

© Copyright 2015–2026 Save My Exams Ltd. All Rights Reserved.
Neither IBO nor College Board were involved in the production of, and do not endorse, the resources created by Save My Exams.